

ing out. Researchers at the Union College in New York conducted two surveys of nearly 600 people in the city in 2015 and found that those who constantly needed online feedback had higher levels of self-doubt and attachment anxiety. "Those who have a lot of self-doubt try to compensate by having a large social circle online," says Dr Harish Shetty, a Mumbai-based psychiatrist. "The same people would behave entirely differently online." This is also true of trolling. Micro behaviour that lets our brains pick up emotional cues offline are missing online. "You cannot see how your words impact another person in cyberspace, as it is largely textual exchanges. It is easier to write something hurtful in the virtual world than say it to a person's face," says Dr Sharma.

Anxiety brought on by doomscrolling, or the continuous exposure to negative news—war, crime, Covid, economic catastrophe—is another consequence of online obsession. "I doomscroll," says Bengaluru's Kapur, "so does my wife. We cannot sleep till we have read the news on our mobile phones, and it is mostly always negative." The Wakefit study found that 57 per cent of its respondents doomscrolled every night. Such anxiety peaked during the pandemic when the deluge of information—as well as misinformation—played havoc on the mental health of a people locked down.

But the lure of the device is so strong that NortonLifeLock's Digital Wellness Report found that 65 per cent of Gen X respondents were happily willing to compromise on sleep and food if they could be online. "The real risk lies in letting such behaviour go on unchecked," says Dr Patil. Help is at hand, provided you are willing to take it.

HOW TO DETOX DIGITALLY

In response to the growing concern over digital overuse, several digital deaddiction centres have come up in India in the past year or so. In December 2021, Tamil Nadu became the first state to launch internet deaddiction centres at all government medical colleges and hospitals. The Kerala government followed suit by announcing plans for digital deaddiction centres for children in the state. Last October, the Kozhikode District Legal Services Society, in association with the district health department, started E-Mochan, a clinic that helps identify IA for early diagnosis and effective treatment. Several private centres, such as the Sakra World Hospital in Bengaluru, Arya Hospital in Chandigarh, Anandvan Addiction Liberation and Rehabilitation Centre in Pune and the Alpha Healing Centre in Vadodara, Gujarat, have all launched programmes for gaming, digital or internet addicts.

Meanwhile, the behaviour clinics at AIIMS and NIMHANS have reported a rise in the number of patients seeking treatment for digital addiction in the past two years. "It is important to recognise and seek counselling at the earliest," says Dr Sharma. "Often people are confused and in denial since the use of digital devices is normal today. But if you feel you cannot be without a device, or you feel anger, stress or depression while using the internet, it is time to get guidance from an expert."

In the case of 19-year-old Ishan Saxena (*name changed*), a gaming addiction had manifested into violent behaviour towards his parents. "We allowed him to take a gap year between school and college because of the pandemic," says his Gurugram-based businessman father. "He used to spend time playing World of Warcraft. Before we knew it, he was playing 15 hours a day." Trouble started when Ishan's younger brother, aged four, also began to learn the game from him. "We separated the siblings. That is when my older son began to throw